# Zhelyo Ivanov

Chief Product Officer | Technical Product Leader


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## 00 / Profile

For over a decade, I've been building products that others thought were impossible. I started by engineering interactive hardware installations, AR experiences, EdTech platforms, and guerrilla social campaigns. I then applied that technical product expertise to FinTech, where I've launched platforms serving 700K+ customers and processing €30M+ in transactions annually. Whether it's experiential, digital platforms, or mobile ecosystems, I solve hard engineering problems and ship products that deliver real business impact at scale.

**My Journey:**

**2016–2021:** Built experiential/interactive products (robotic installations, AR experiences, national education platforms) – engineering-driven executions with measurable business impact

**2021–2023:** Applied product expertise to FinTech – launched 3 products from 0→1 (€30M+ annual volume)

**2023–Present:** Product ecosystem leadership – CPO managing 5 brands, 40+ person team, platform transformation

## 01 / Core Competencies

**Product Leadership:** 0→1 Product Development · Platform Strategy · Full Product Lifecycle Management · Multi-Brand Portfolio Leadership · Product Roadmapping · Technical Product Management · Go-to-Market Strategy

**Technical Expertise:** Hardware Integration (Arduino/ECU) · Mobile UI Architecture (iOS/Android/PWA) · API Integration · Web Scraping & Data Processing · Multi-Platform Streaming · CDP Integration (Bloomreach) · Payment Systems · E-commerce Plugins · Analytics Platforms · SaaS Platforms

**Crypto & Blockchain:** Web3/DeFi product strategy · Crypto trading since 2017 · Understanding of blockchain mechanics, wallet integration, DeFi protocols · Passion for financial freedom through decentralized finance.

**Methodologies & Frameworks:** Agile/Scrum · North Star Metric · OKRs & KPIs · User Testing & Focus Groups · A/B Testing · Product Metrics · User Research · Data-Driven Decision Making

**Business Impact:** €30M+ Transaction Volume · 700K Customer Base · 50K App Downloads · Award-Winning Solutions · Market Survival (competitors closed) · Exceptional Retention Rates

**Strategic Skills:** Product-Market Fit · Customer-Driven Pivots · Crisis Navigation (COVID remote pivot, EURO currency change) · Cross-Functional Team Leadership · Stakeholder Management · Budget Management (contractors, external partners)

## 02 / Professional Experience

### Credissimo

**Chief Product Officer** | *November 2023 – Present*

*I run product for Credissimo, one of Bulgaria's biggest FinTech (700K customers, 5 countries). Leading a 40-person cross-functional team (Product Managers, iOS/Android Developers, Backend Engineers) building everything from loan platforms to a virtual payment card launching this year. Navigate complex KYC/AML requirements across different country operations, balancing regulatory compliance with user experience. Currently responsible for strategy, and execution. Managing 5-brand product portfolio and internal ERP/CRM SaaS systems. I also Define product roadmaps using North Star Metric framework and manage product development budgets including contractor partnerships.*

#### NATIVE MOBILE PLATFORM TRANSFORMATION (2025)

Led dual-brand iOS/Android platform from concept to launch in 8 months (3 months planning + 5 months development), building shared architecture enabling rapid multi-brand feature deployment. Conducted extensive user testing with focus groups to validate onboarding flows and UI variants before development.

- **Product Architecture:** Common mobile UI framework, unified onboarding, design library, Bloomreach CDP integration with multiple API connections for automated communication, business account registration, analytics infrastructure
- **User Research:** Extensively tested user flows, onboarding processes, and UI variants with user groups before development phase. Conducted focus groups for design validation
- **Crisis Management:** Bulgaria adopted EURO currency mid-project – rebuilt entire interface (all prices, calculations, labels) in 2 months while maintaining live operations with zero downtime

- **Performance (7 months):** 50K downloads exceeding board targets; 31% of all loan applications now originate from mobile – major channel shift achieved. Turns out our people were waiting for a mobile-first experience.
- **Strategic Expansion:** Building platform ecosystem – Virtual Card integration with global e-money institution (launch H1 2026), gamification infrastructure, loyalty program refurbishment with points-for-loan-repayment innovation

### CREDISSIMO REBRAND & PLATFORM REDESIGN (Summer 2025)

After launching Credissimo app (June 2025), led comprehensive brand refresh in partnership with external branding studio. Completely reskinned both mobile app and web platform during summer to align with modernized brand identity.

**Product Development Manager** | *January 2023 – November 2023*

*Led end-to-end development of three new FinTech brands from concept to market in under 2 years. Managed cross-functional teams and external partners across strategy, branding, UX, development, and go-to-market.*

**Key Product Launches:**

**Umo.bg** – *Smart Credit Platform (Launched October 2024)*

Identified market gap: consumers with good income and financial literacy but lacking credit score. New credit model rewarding payment precision.

- **Product Innovation:** Instant re-borrow at 1/3 repayment threshold (3 clicks, no re-application); 30-day upsell window for pre-approved credit; slider-based UX showing real-time contract terms; named 'Umo' (Bulgarian for 'clever')
- **Technical Execution:** PWA platform, stripped-down conversion flow, integrated with Credissimo ERP/CRM SaaS, educational content strategy
- **Performance (16 months):** Achieved exceptional 50% repeat customer rate, validating re-borrow mechanic and product-market fit. Scaled client base while maintaining strict credit standards, meeting all growth targets

**PlatiPosle.bg** – *Buy Now Pay Later Platform (Launched May 2023)*

Built one of Bulgaria's first BNPL services with revolutionary dual-channel approach. Survived market consolidation as competitors (Rilla, NewPay, Mokka) closed operations.

- **Phase 1 Innovation:** Novel 'copy/paste URL' method – customers enter any e-commerce URL, platform scrapes product data automatically, no merchant integration required. Validated demand with zero friction
- **Phase 2 Scale:** Observed returning customers purchasing from major chains – built embedded checkout integrations. Developed custom plugins for all Bulgarian e-commerce platforms (CloudCart, WooCommerce, OpenCart

- **Current Model:** Dual-channel flexibility – 1/3 of transactions still via URL method, 2/3 via embedded checkout
- **Business Impact:** Established BNPL marketplace with hundreds of merchant partnerships across major e-commerce platforms. Scaled rapidly while competitors closed operations. Serves credit-underserved consumers enabling appliances, education, professional development

**Nolus.io** – DeFi Lending Protocol (Web3)
*Brand Strategy & Go-to-Market Lead* | May 2022 – October 2022

Part of core launch team for decentralized lending protocol on Cosmos blockchain

- Developed brand positioning and GTM strategy for DeFi protocol targeting mainstream crypto users

**Xtra.bg** – *Next-Generation Personal Loan Platform (Launched January 2022)*

Built Credissimo's first 'next-generation' product from concept to launch. Given full ownership after proving capabilities on main brand – defined strategy, UX, development, go-to-market. Designed KYC onboarding flows meeting Bulgarian National Bank requirements while maintaining high conversion rates

- **Technical Innovation:** First Progressive Web App (PWA) at Credissimo. 'Completely new ethos' in user profiling targeting younger, financially literate consumers with lower APR and insurance packages
- **Business Impact:** Scaled to thousands of active borrowers through rigorous bank-level screening (5.6% approval rate demonstrates credit quality focus). Achieved consistent 20% YoY growth with strong unit economics and product-market fit
- **Career Impact:** Success of Xtra launch directly led to CPO promotion (November 2023)

**Brand Manager** | *April 2021 – January 2023*

Shaped brand marketing strategy, product analytics, and innovation for Credissimo's core brand. Translated user insights into refined digital experiences. Led cross-functional initiatives with UX/Engineering teams to optimize launches.

## 03 / Experiential & Interactive Product Portfolio (2016–2021)

*Led engineering-driven product development in experiential technology across major brands and national institutions. Built complex hardware/software systems solving 'impossible' technical challenges with measurable business outcomes.*

### Mediapool.bg – 'You Are What You Read' Anti-Fake News Platform

*Mediapool.bg / Saatchi & Saatchi Bulgaria (Interactive Team) | Director of Extraordinary | 2017*

We fought oligarch-controlled media and fake news epidemic in Bulgaria with a clever hack. Created fictitious news generator turning users into distribution mechanism for media literacy education, reaching half the nation's population.

**The Challenge:**

Bulgarian population unable to identify fake news; oligarchs had purchased mass media outlets pumping daily misinformation with catastrophic national impact. Brief: How to fight this trend with limited budget.

**Product Solution:**

- **Fake News Generator Platform:** Built functional website enabling anyone to create realistic fake news articles using actual expressions from fake news outlets
- **Viral Distribution:** Social media sharing built-in – users spread their fake articles across networks
- **Educational Redirect:** Clicking shared articles redirected to landing page explaining fake news problem with metrics, data, and manual on spotting misinformation
- **Behavioral Design:** Turned users into distribution mechanism – they created and spread the education themselves

**Impact & Scale:**

- **700,000 website visits**
- **260,000 user-generated fake news articles** created and distributed
- **3.5 million people reached** (approximately half of Bulgaria's population)
- **€200,000+ equivalent media value from €500 budget** (400:1 ROI)
- National media coverage for weeks – became main national talking point

**Awards & Recognition:**

- **Agency of the Year 2017** (FARA) – Saatchi & Saatchi Sofia
- **4 Gold Awards for campaign**: Social Media ('Create Fake News'), Digital Campaign ('You Are What You Read'), Integrated Campaign, Media Campaign
- **1 Silver Award**: Non-standard Use of Digital and Social Channels
- **2 Bronze Awards**: Advertising Text, Online Advertising

**Social Impact:** Fought oligarch-controlled media misinformation at national scale using clever product design that turned users into educators. Demonstrated power of viral mechanics for social good.

### Finansiada – National Financial Literacy Platform

*DSK Bank (via Digitas Sofia) | Senior Experience Engineer | 2019–2020*

Designed and built proprietary EdTech platform addressing Bulgaria's financial literacy crisis for nation's largest bank. Combined web application, live game mechanics, and broadcast infrastructure.

**Year 1 (2019) – Hybrid Physical/Digital:**

- Built end-to-end platform: registration system, educational CMS (thousands of pages), timed qualification tests, custom buzzer hardware, digital signage integration, live streaming to 15K viewers
- 672 teams (1,344+ students & parents) competed nationwide
- **Won Gold Award (PR Priz 2019) in CSR category**

**Year 2 (2020) – COVID Remote Innovation:**

- Pivoted to fully remote in 3 months when all events canceled – built first-of-its-kind multi-platform streaming: orchestrated Zoom (contestant feeds), Kahoot (live scoring), Facebook Live (7,600+ viewers) with 37-person remote production crew
- 993 teams (+48% YoY growth), 703 qualified, 6 scholarships awarded
- **Zero technical failures** during live multi-room elimination broadcasts
- **Client testimonial:** *'The technological solution…has no analogue' – Nikolay Takuchev, Head of Marketing, DSK Bank*

**Total Impact:** 1,665 teams (3,330+ participants) across 2 years; 22,600+ live viewers; established DSK Bank as national leader in financial education; created reusable platform for ongoing program

### Nissan LEAF: Conquer the Future – Interactive Launch Experience

*Nissan Bulgaria (via Saatchi & Saatchi) | Director of Extraordinary | 2017–2018*

Engineered first-of-its-kind interactive vehicle experience for next-generation electric vehicle launch, targeting early adopters and automobile journalists.

- **Technical Achievement:** Captured production vehicle's ECU signals via Arduino; mapped steering and pedal inputs to control real-time 3D projected environment ('time travel through space'). Explained single-pedal drive, range, navigation through gameplay while maintaining vehicle warranty/safety compliance
- **Business Impact:** 5,200 physical test drives in installation (exceeded dealer's annual showroom traffic), 58,000 online content interactions, sales exceeded Nissan's projections
- Press amplification through featured automobile journalist coverage

### Zagorka Interactive Christmas Wish Tree

*Zagorka Beer (via Saatchi & Saatchi) | Director of Extraordinary | 2016*

Engineered and deployed interactive LED installation combining hardware (1000+ RPM spinning mechanism), software (global message platform), and real-time visualization for global Christmas wish campaign.

- **Technical Challenge:** Created persistence-of-vision LED display at extreme RPM. Overcame 'deemed unsolvable' high-speed LED filming via custom DSLR configuration and real-time post-production
- **End-to-End System:** Web platform → LED visualization → automated GIF capture → personalized delivery
- **Global Impact:** 30,000 messages from around the world processed and distributed as personalized Christmas cards

### Additional Agency Experience (2016–2021)

Led experiential technology projects at Digitas Sofia (2019–2021) and Saatchi & Saatchi Bulgaria (2016–2019) for major brands including A1, Audi, Coca-Cola, DSK Bank, Kaufland, Nissan, Samsung, and Zagorka. Earned 10+ industry awards including Agency of the Year 2017 (FARA), multiple Gold, Silver, and Bronze awards across digital campaigns, social media, and integrated marketing.

## 04 / Education & Languages

**New Bulgarian University** | Bachelor's in Advertisement, Marketing | 2007–2011

**Languages:** Bulgarian (Native), English (Advanced), French (Conversational